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Influencer Authenticity vs. AI-Generated Content: An Empirical Study on Consumer Skepticism, Brand Credibility, and Purchase Intention in the Age of Generative AI

Under-Graduate Minor Project Report
(Digital Marketing)

BACHELOR OF TECHNOLOGY

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ABSTRACT

Influencer marketing has become a central pillar of digital marketing strategy, with the global market valued at approximately $32.55 billion in 2025 and projected to reach $52 billion by 2028. However, the rapid rise of generative AI tools such as ChatGPT, Midjourney, and Sora has created a fundamental tension in the industry. While brands and influencers increasingly leverage these tools for content creation efficiency, consumers are growing more skeptical of content that lacks perceived authenticity. Research indicates that only 15% of consumers highly trust AI-generated influencer content, and nearly a third report being less likely to engage with brands that use AI-generated advertising.

This study investigates how perceived influencer authenticity, AI content awareness, content transparency, and parasocial relationship strength influence consumer skepticism toward influencer marketing in the age of generative AI. The conceptual model, grounded in the Persuasion Knowledge Model (Friestad & Wright, 1994), Source Credibility Theory (Ohanian, 1990), Parasocial Interaction Theory (Horton & Wohl, 1956), and the Stimulus–Organism–Response framework (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974), positions consumer skepticism as a mediating construct between influencer/content characteristics and two key outcomes: brand credibility and purchase intention. Six hypotheses are proposed, with four antecedents expected to influence skepticism, which in turn affects downstream consumer behaviour.

The study employs a quantitative, survey-based research design using a structured questionnaire with 26 Likert-scale items adapted from established scales in the literature. Data will be collected from Indian digital consumers aged 18 and above through an online Google Forms survey distributed via social media platforms. Analysis will involve descriptive statistics, reliability testing (Cronbach's alpha), Pearson correlation analysis, multiple regression modelling using Python, and Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modelling (PLS-SEM) using SmartPLS 4.0.

Work completed so far includes the development of the complete conceptual model, formulation of six testable hypotheses, comprehensive literature review drawing from 20+ references (2024–2026), and the design of a validated survey instrument. The questionnaire has been structured and is ready for pilot testing in the coming weeks. This research aims to provide empirical insights into managing the authenticity–AI tension in influencer marketing, with implications for digital marketers, brand managers, and platform designers.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction to the Area of Work

Influencer marketing has become a part of digital marketing changing how brands talk to consumers through trusted social media personalities. The global influencer marketing market was worth about $32.55 billion in 2025. Is expected to grow to $52 billion by 2028 (Statista, 2024). Unlike advertising influencer marketing depends mainly on realness, followers follow influencers because they think the posts show real opinions, real life moments and honest tips (Morhart et al., 2015; Zheng, 2024). A big change is happening. The quick spread of AI tools such as ChatGPT for writing Midjourney and DALL-E for pictures and Sora for video is changing how influencer marketing makes content.

1.2 Present-Day Scenario

The marketing world in 2025–2026 has a strange mix. AI-generated articles are now common than human-written ones online for the first time (Hootsuite Social Trends, 2026). The Interactive Advertising Bureau says that 40% of video ads will use generative AI by 2026. But consumers are becoming more wary: 15% of people put a lot of trust in AI influencers (California Management Review, 2025) and almost one third say they would be less likely to pick a brand that uses AI-generated ads (Hootsuite, 2026). India with, than 820 million internet users (IAMAI, 2023) is one of the fastest-growing digital and influencer marketing markets worldwide, so it is a key place to study this change.

1.3 Need for the Research Study

Despite the rapid integration of AI in influencer marketing, there is a critical gap in understanding how consumers psychologically respond when they discover or suspect that influencer content is AI-generated or AI-assisted. Most existing research focuses on fully virtual AI influencers (such as Lil Miquela) rather than the far more common scenario of human influencers utilising AI tools to create content. Additionally, no study has integrated perceived authenticity, AI content awareness, content transparency, and parasocial relationship strength in a single empirical model. The Indian consumer context, despite being among the world's largest digital markets with unique regulatory developments (Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023), remains empirically underexplored.

1.4 Problem Statement

How do perceived influencer authenticity, AI content awareness, content transparency, and parasocial relationships influence consumer skepticism, and how does skepticism in turn affect brand credibility and purchase intention among Indian digital consumers?

1.5 Research Objectives

The study aims to achieve the following objectives:

- To examine the relationship between perceived influencer authenticity, AI content awareness, content transparency, parasocial relationship strength, and consumer skepticism.
- To analyse how consumer skepticism mediates the effect of influencer and content characteristics on brand credibility and purchase intention.
- To identify which factors most strongly drive or mitigate consumer skepticism toward influencer content in the AI era.

1.5.1 Research Questions

- RQ1: How do perceived authenticity, AI content awareness, transparency, and parasocial relationships affect consumer skepticism toward influencer marketing?
- RQ2: Does consumer skepticism negatively impact brand credibility and purchase intention?
- RQ3: Which influencer and content characteristics most strongly predict consumer skepticism?

1.6 Target Specifications and Significance

The results of this study will help marketers, brand managers, people who design platforms and government officials. Learning which factors strongly cause or reduce doubts will help people create strategies that are based on real evidence for telling people when content is made by AI showing that it is real and building trust in partnerships with influencers. In India the results will also help with rules under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act (2023) about making AI content clear. The results will give advice, for making influencer marketing work better in a world where AI is used a lot.

CHAPTER 2

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Present State and Recent Developments

Influencer marketing has changed a lot because of AI technologies. I think a journal in the Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science (Lee et al. 2025) shows that with evidence from 1,531 effect sizes across 251 papers influencer marketing practices do affect consumer behaviors and decisions using persuasion knowledge as the mechanism. The study found that post characteristics such as hedonic value follower characteristics such as social identity and influencer marketing characteristics such as credibility and expertise were key predictors of both transactional and non-transactional marketing outcomes.

The virtual influencer market reached $4.6 billion in 2024 with a growth rate of 38.9% (JTAER, 2025). Studies for the California Management Review (2025) showed that audiences used an average of 3.9 authenticity signals when judging content credibility. Meanwhile the HubSpot State of Marketing report (2026) says that 61% of marketers believe marketing will face its disruption in 20 years because of AI and Hootsuite's Social Trends Report (2026) notes that AI-generated articles on the web now outnumber human-written ones, for the first time.

2.2 Theoretical Foundations

2.2.1 Persuasion Knowledge Model (PKM)

The Persuasion Knowledge Model, introduced by Friestad and Wright in 1994 shows how consumers learn about persuasion tactics and use that knowledge to control how easily they are persuaded. This study looks at how the Persuasion Knowledge Model helps us understand how consumer awareness of AI-generated content works as a tactic. When consumers notice they are being persuaded consumers use strategies, for example skepticism to fight back against unwanted persuasion. The JAMS journal, in a paper by Lee and colleagues in 2025 found that in 251 studies Persuasion Knowledge Model lowered influencer credibility and consumer skepticism acted as a bridge between content characteristics and marketing outcomes. Consumer awareness of AI-generated content is critical, for protecting against bias. The Persuasion Knowledge Model explains this pattern. Shows how defensive strategies can reduce the impact of unwanted persuasion. Skepticism remains a tool for consumers to protect themselves. Influencer credibility is often diminished when Persuasion Knowledge Model is applied and marketing outcomes shift accordingly.

2.2.2 Source Credibility Theory

Source Credibility Theory traces its roots to research conducted by Hovland, Janis, and Kelley (1953) with later developments by Ohanian (1990). This theory highlights the importance of trust and believability of the message source in influencer marketing. The current study's focus on the role of AI in influencer marketing practices may limit consumer trust in the information provided by influencers. Ujjainwala's (2025) experiment used a between-subject design to establish that virtual influencers significantly reduced perceived authenticity and brand credibility as compared to human influencers.

2.2.3 Parasocial Interaction Theory

Parasocial Interaction Theory was created by Horton and Wohl in 1956. Then expanded by Dibble, Hartmann and Rosaen in 2016. These researchers focused on the relationships that people form with influencers through social media. Liu and Zheng in 2024 wrote an article in Nature's Humanities and Social Sciences Communications. They said that authenticity is very important in creating relationships. These relationships then have an effect on buying decisions. How trustworthy a brand seems. The study also found that persuasion knowledge has an influence on the connection, between parasocial relationships and brand credibility.

2.2.4 Stimulus–Organism–Response (S-O-R) Framework

The S-O-R model (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974) provides the theoretical basis for the conceptual model applied in the current study. Stimuli in the case of influencer marketing include influencer and content characteristics, while organism incorporates the mediating role of consumer skepticism. In turn, the response variable is manifested in consumer brand credibility and purchase intention. Bigné, Andreu, and Gnoth (2005) justify the mediation role of consumer skepticism, arguing that not all content characteristics directly influence purchase intentions.

2.3 Influencer Authenticity and Consumer Behaviour

Consumer perceptions of influencer authenticity has been at the center of many studies investigating the impact of influencer marketing on consumer behaviors. Influencer authenticity refers to genuineness, originality, and "true-to-self" presentation (Morhart et al., 2015). Liu and Zheng (2024) established a positive relationship between the informative value of influencer content, authenticity, and homophily and parasocial relationships, which in turn predicted purchase intention and brand credibility. Research published in MDPI Open Journal (2025) revealed a paradoxical relationship between trust and purchase intention in the context of influencer marketing. According to the article, consumer trust in influencers' content increased persuasion knowledge, thereby converting trust into skepticism.

2.4 AI-Generated Content and Consumer Perceptions

Ujjainwala (2025) ran a study with 320 media users to see how people feel about AI influencers. The results showed that AI influencers actually make people trust brands less and

feel like the content is not real when compared to influencers. It also turns out that telling people away that an influencer is AI makes these problems even worse. However people who know a lot about tools did not feel this way as much.

Another study, in the Journal of Theoretical and Applied Electronic Commerce Research (JTAER, 2025) looked at 414 people to see why consumers engage with or buy from AI-generated influencers. The researchers used survey data and math models to find the truth. This study found that if an AI-generated virtual influencer is credible gives info and looks human people are more likely to engage and buy things. On the hand just being funny or looking pretty did not make people want to buy things from the AI-generated virtual influencer.

2.5 Consumer Skepticism and Persuasion Knowledge

An analysis conducted among Gen Z consumers published in IJRISS (2025) revealed that consumer skepticism was highest in the case of macro-influencers as compared to user-generated content, with transparency positively predicting consumer trust in influencers. Persuasion Knowledge Framework (Eisend & Tarrahi, 2022) provides empirical evidence on the negative role of consumers' skepticism regarding the underlying persuasive intent of influencer marketing practices. Negative perceptions of persuasion knowledge significantly predicted unfavorable attitudes towards advertisements, brands, and purchase intentions (Evans et al., 2017; Woodroof et al., 2020). In the context of influencer marketing, increased disclosure of brand-influencer partnerships predicted higher consumer credibility in the case of influencers (Evans et al., 2017; Woodroof et al., 2020). Thus, applying the principle to AI influencers could mitigate consumer skepticism to a considerable extent.

2.6 Parasocial Relationships in the AI Age

A study in the Springer's Discover Sustainability journal (2025) looked at users. This study found that brands can use AI influencers to make emotional bonds with people. Some AI influencers can even build communities better than influencers. However many people still feel skeptical about the long-term credibility of AI influencers. Davlembayeva's (2025) article in the British Journal of Management journal showed that we still need to do research to understand what makes people engage with virtual influencers. Also a study by Farivar, Wang and Turel's (2024) in the Computers, in Human Behavior journal found that parasocial intimacy helps. When people feel this intimacy they are less likely to doubt or question promotional information.

2.7 Conceptual Model

Based on the reviewed literature and theoretical foundations, a conceptual model has been developed explaining how influencer and content characteristics affect consumer behavioural outcomes through the mediating mechanism of consumer skepticism. The model positions

Perceived Authenticity (PA), AI Content Awareness (ACA), Content Transparency (CT), and Parasocial Relationship (PSR) as independent variables. These factors are hypothesised to influence Consumer Skepticism (CS), which acts as a mediating construct. Consumer Skepticism is expected to negatively impact Brand Credibility (BC) and Purchase Intention (PI). The model follows S-O-R logic: influencer/content attributes serve as stimuli, skepticism represents the organismic state, and brand credibility and purchase intention constitute the behavioural responses.

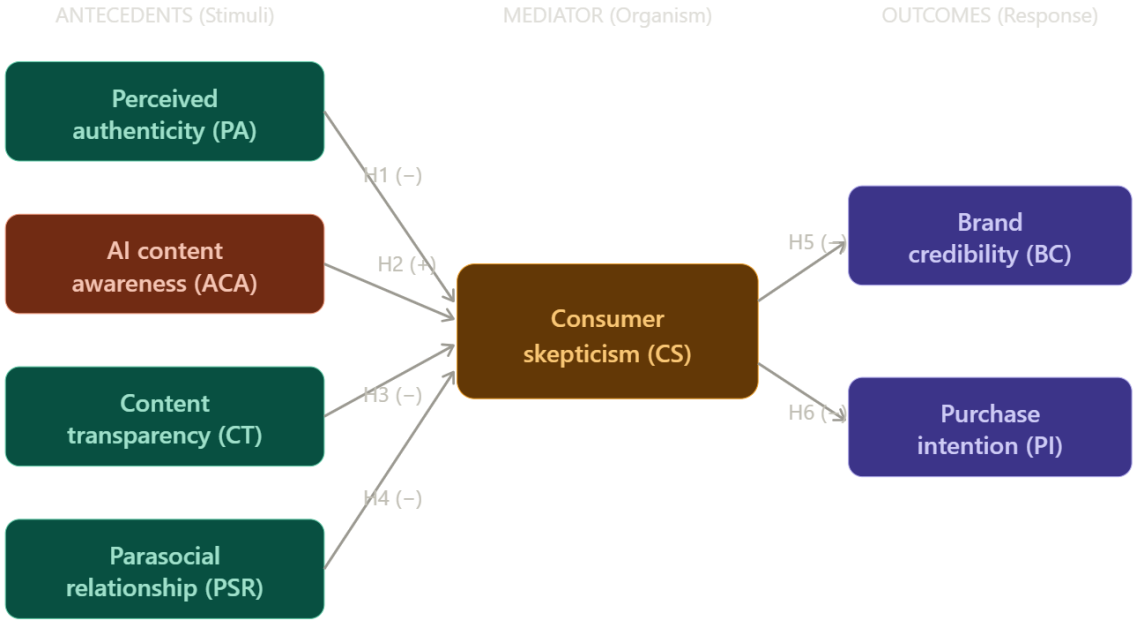


Table 2.1: Constructs' Operational Definitions

Construct	Definition in the Study
Perceived Authenticity (PA)	The degree to which consumers perceive an influencer's content as genuine, original, and reflecting the influencer's true opinions and personality.
AI Content Awareness (ACA)	The consumer's awareness or suspicion that an influencer's content has been generated or significantly assisted by AI tools.

Content Transparency (CT)	The extent to which an influencer or brand openly discloses the use of AI tools, sponsorships, or other non-organic elements in content creation.
Parasocial Relationship (PSR)	The perceived one-sided emotional bond and sense of intimacy that a follower develops with an influencer through repeated content exposure.
Consumer Skepticism (CS)	The consumer's tendency to doubt, question, or distrust the sincerity and motives behind influencer-endorsed content.
Brand Credibility (BC)	The consumer's perception of the endorsed brand's trustworthiness, expertise, and reliability as influenced by the influencer's endorsement.
Purchase Intention (PI)	The consumer's stated likelihood of purchasing a product or service after exposure to influencer marketing content.

2.8 Hypotheses Development

2.8.1 Perceived Authenticity and Consumer Skepticism

When people believe that an influencer is real and true they are less likely to be doubtful. Signs of authenticity like sharing experiences showing unpolished videos and having clear values help lower the level of persuasion knowledge.. Zheng (2024) and Morhart et al. (2015) Found that authenticity helps build connections and makes people less defensive when they see marketing messages.

H1: Perceived authenticity has a significant negative effect on consumer skepticism.

2.8.2 AI Content Awareness and Consumer Skepticism

When people know or think that content is made by AI it makes them more alert and suspicious. The idea that there is human involvement makes people question if the influencer really believes what they are saying. Ujjainwala (2025) found that AI influencers make people feel trust and less authenticity compared to real people.

H2: AI content awareness has a significant positive effect on consumer skepticism.

2.8.3 Content Transparency and Consumer Skepticism

Being clear and open about using AI can help reduce doubt. Evans et al. (2017) And Woodroof et al. (2020) Found that when brands clearly say they are working with influencers people trust them more. The PKM research says that being open helps avoid the shock of finding out which can cause strong negative reactions.

H3: Content transparency has a significant negative effect on consumer skepticism.

2.8.4 Parasocial Relationship and Consumer Skepticism

Strong emotional connections between followers and influencers can help reduce doubt. When people feel close to an influencer they are less likely to look at the content with an eye. Farivar, Wang and Turel (2024) found that close emotional ties make people less defensive when they see content.

H4: Parasocial relationship strength has a significant negative effect on consumer skepticism.

2.8.5 Consumer Skepticism and Brand Credibility

Doubt about influencer content can also affect the brand they promote. When people question if the influencer is being genuine they also question the brand. The PKM theory says that if people think the motives are bad they form opinions about the brand (Friestad & Wright 1994; Erdem & Swait 2004).

H5: Consumer skepticism has a significant negative effect on brand credibility.

2.8.6 Consumer Skepticism and Purchase Intention

High levels of doubt make people less likely to follow influencer suggestions. The JAMS meta-analysis (Lee et al. 2025) looked at 251 studies. Found that skepticism lowers the chance of making a purchase. Persuasion knowledge acts as a link between what the content's like and what people do.

H6: Consumer skepticism has a significant negative effect on purchase intention.

Table 2.2: Summary of Hypotheses

Hyp.	Statement	Direction
H1	Perceived Authenticity has a significant negative effect on Consumer Skepticism.	−
H2	AI Content Awareness has a significant positive effect on Consumer Skepticism.	+
H3	Content Transparency has a significant negative effect on Consumer Skepticism.	−
H4	Parasocial Relationship has a significant negative effect on Consumer Skepticism.	−
H5	Consumer Skepticism has a significant negative effect on Brand Credibility.	−
H6	Consumer Skepticism has a significant negative effect on Purchase Intention.	−

CHAPTER 3

METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Approach and Study Design

This research follows a quantitative, hypothesis-testing approach. The design is descriptive with respect to characterising consumer attitudes towards AI-assisted influencer content, and correlational with respect to examining the relationships specified in the conceptual model. The design is cross-sectional: all constructs are measured at a single point in time from a single source. It therefore supports inference about the existence, direction and strength of association between constructs, but not about causal direction. Statements in this report are framed accordingly.

3.2 Data Collection Method

Data were collected through a self-administered online questionnaire hosted on Google Forms and distributed through social media (Instagram, LinkedIn, WhatsApp), email and messaging applications. Participation was voluntary and anonymous, and consent was obtained through the first item of the instrument.

3.3 Sample Design

Element	Specification
Study population	Indian internet users aged 18 and above who follow at least one social media influencer and have encountered influencer-promoted content within the past six months
Sampling frame	No complete sampling frame exists for this population; non-probability sampling was therefore necessary
Sampling method	Convenience sampling supplemented by snowball referral
Sample unit	Individual social media user
Pilot sample size	n = 55
Main sample size	N = 389

3.4 Instrument and Questionnaire Development

The questionnaire comprises 26 items measuring the seven constructs, each on a five-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree to 5 = Strongly Agree), preceded by consent and screening questions and demographic items, and followed by an attention-check item and an optional open-ended question. Items were adapted from validated scales as set out in Table 2.1. The complete instrument as administered is reproduced in Annexure I.

3.5 Statistical Tools and Methods (Planned)

Analysis will be conducted in Python using pandas, NumPy, SciPy and statsmodels, with partial least squares structural equation modelling carried out in SmartPLS 4.0. The following analyses are planned:

- Descriptive statistics and tests of univariate and multivariate normality.
- Internal consistency reliability (Cronbach's alpha), corrected item-total correlations and alpha-if-item-deleted.
- Harman's single-factor test for common method bias (Podsakoff et al., 2003).
- Pearson and Spearman correlation analysis.
- Multiple regression analysis with variance inflation factors and residual diagnostics.
- Bootstrapped mediation analysis using 5,000 resamples with bias-corrected confidence intervals (Preacher & Hayes, 2008).
- PLS-SEM measurement model assessment: outer loadings, Cronbach's alpha, rho_A, composite reliability, average variance extracted, the Fornell-Larcker criterion, the heterotrait-monotrait ratio and cross-loadings.
- PLS-SEM structural model assessment: path coefficients with 5,000 bootstrap subsamples, coefficient of determination, effect size and predictive relevance through blindfolding.

Sample size adequacy has been assessed against the ten-times rule (Hair et al., 2021), which requires at least ten observations per arrow directed at the most complex construct. The most complex construct in the model receives six arrows, giving a minimum of 60 observations; the analytical sample of N = 389 satisfies this criterion. Using the inverse square root method (Kock & Hadaya, 2018), a sample of this size will be able to detect standardised path coefficients of approximately 0.21 or greater at the 5 per cent level with 80 per cent power. This limitation will be stated when the results are reported.

CHAPTER 4

WORK DONE SO FAR AND OUTCOMES

This chapter reports the work completed to date. The literature review, conceptual model and hypothesis set are finalised; the survey instrument has been developed, piloted and revised; and data collection for both the pilot and the main study is complete. Statistical analysis of the main study data has not yet been carried out and is described in Chapter 5.

4.1 Questionnaire Development and Sources

The instrument was developed from the conceptual framework set out in Chapter 2, with items adapted from validated scales. Perceived Authenticity items were adapted from Morhart et al. (2015) and Napoli et al. (2014); Parasocial Relationship items from Dibble, Hartmann and Rosaen (2016); Consumer Skepticism items from Obermiller and Spangenberg (1998); Brand Credibility items from Erdem and Swait (2004); and Purchase Intention items from Dodds, Monroe and Grewal (1991) and Spears and Singh (2004). Content Transparency items were developed from the disclosure literature (Evans et al., 2017; Woodroof et al., 2020). AI Content Awareness items were developed for this study, as no established scale addresses consumer awareness of generative AI in influencer content.

The instrument comprises 26 measurement items across seven constructs, three consent and screening items, four demographic items, one attention-check item and one optional open-ended item, giving 35 items in total.

4.2 Pilot Study

Pilot study has been conducted to check the clarity of the items, whether the groups of items formed a scale, and to identify misunderstandings, a pilot study was conducted before the data collection period of the main study. The pilot study was conducted using the same recruitment methods as the main study, and was open from 24 to 26 June 2026. Out of 55 submissions, 41 were retained after filtering for consent, qualifications, completeness of the submission, and patterns in their responses. Since our proposal called for a pilot study of 30 to 50 usable responses, the final number is well within this range.

4.2.1 Pilot Sample Profile

Demographic	N (%)
Age group	18–24 36 (88%), 25–34 4 (10%), 35–44 1 (2%)
Gender	Male 23 (56%), Female 18 (44%)
Social media usage	Multiple times daily 28 (68%), Daily 12 (29%), Several times a week 1 (2%)
Platforms used (multi-select)	Instagram 40 (98%), YouTube 30 (73%), LinkedIn 8 (20%), Snapchat 8 (20%), Twitter-X 7 (17%), Other 3 (7%), Facebook 2 (5%)

Seen influencer content in past 6 months	Yes 38 (93%), No 2 (5%), Not sure 1 (2%)
Attention check (QC1)	M = 4.37, SD = 0.86; 36 (88%) selected 4 or 5

Table 4.1 Pilot Sample Demographics (n = 41)

The pilot sample is young and highly engaged with social media, which is the profile the study is designed to reach. Almost nine in ten respondents fall in the 18 to 24 age band, and 97 per cent report using social media daily or more often, so every respondent is exposed to influencer content frequently enough to hold meaningful views about it. Gender is close to balanced, with 56 per cent male and 44 per cent female. Instagram and YouTube dominate platform use, at 98 and 73 per cent respectively, which matches the platforms on which influencer marketing is most concentrated in India.

The attention-check item returned a mean of 4.37 on the five-point scale, with 88 per cent of respondents selecting 4 or 5. Taken with the absence of straight-lined responses in the retained set, this indicates that the questionnaire was being read rather than clicked through, and that the pilot responses are a sound basis for judging item performance. The concentration in the youngest age band is noted as a constraint on generalisability rather than a defect in the pilot, whose purpose is instrument refinement.

4.2.2 Item-Level Descriptive Statistics

Item	Mean	SD	Min	Max
PA1	3.78	0.88	1	5
PA2	3.24	1.02	1	5
PA3	3.24	1.16	1	5
PA4	3.37	1.04	1	5
ACA1	4.02	0.85	2	5
ACA2	3.63	0.94	2	5
ACA3	3.41	0.92	2	5
ACA4	3.61	1.12	1	5
CT1	3.68	1.01	1	5
CT2	2.85	0.99	1	5
CT3	3.66	0.85	2	5
CT4	3.17	0.95	1	5
PSR1	2.85	1.17	1	5
PSR2	3.00	1.10	1	5
PSR3	3.68	1.06	1	5
PSR4	2.98	1.25	1	5
CS1	3.46	0.98	1	5
CS2	3.85	1.11	1	5
CS3	3.63	1.02	1	5
CS4	3.44	1.07	1	5
BC1	2.93	0.91	1	5

BC2	2.85	0.94	1	5
BC3	3.10	1.11	1	5
PI1	3.20	1.12	1	5
PI2	3.15	1.11	1	5
PI3	3.10	1.04	1	5

Table 4.2 Item Descriptives (n = 41)

The item-level descriptives indicate that respondents used the full range of the five-point Likert scale across all constructs, with means generally falling in the mid-to-high range and standard deviations between 0.85 and 1.26. That dispersion matters: items with little variance cannot correlate with anything, so adequate spread at the pilot stage is a precondition for the correlation, regression and structural analyses planned for the main study.

A study in the Springer's Discover Sustainability journal (2025) looked at users. This study found that brands can use AI influencers to make emotional bonds with people. Some AI influencers can even build communities better than influencers. However many people still feel skeptical about the long-term credibility of AI influencers. Davlembayeva's (2025) article in the British Journal of Management journal showed that we still need to do research to understand what makes people engage with virtual influencers. Also a study by Farivar, Wang and Turel's (2024) in the Computers, in Human Behavior journal found that parasocial intimacy helps. When people feel this intimacy they are less likely to doubt or question promotional information.

4.2.3 Reliability Analysis

Construct	# Items	Cronbach's α (95% CI)
Perceived Authenticity (PA)	4	0.86 [0.77, 0.92]
AI Content Awareness (ACA)	4	0.64 [0.43, 0.79]
Content Transparency (CT)	4	0.64 [0.42, 0.79]
Parasocial Relationship (PSR)	4	0.82 [0.70, 0.89]
Consumer Skepticism (CS)	4	0.83 [0.73, 0.90]
Brand Credibility (BC)	3	0.87 [0.78, 0.92]
Purchase Intention (PI)	3	0.73 [0.54, 0.85]

Table 4.3 Reliability Summary (n = 41)

The internal consistency of the measurement instrument was evaluated using Cronbach's alpha for each construct, with confidence intervals computed by the method of Feldt (1965). Alpha values range from 0.64 to 0.87. Five of the seven constructs meet or exceed the conventional threshold of .70 (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994), indicating that the items within each of those constructs measure the same underlying concept consistently. Two constructs fall below the threshold and are examined at item level in Section 4.2.4.

Specifically:

- Brand Credibility (BC) returned α = 0.87 — the strongest scale in the instrument, indicating that the three items capture a single coherent judgement of the endorsed brand.
- Perceived Authenticity (PA) returned α = 0.86 — showing that respondents evaluate influencer genuineness consistently across phrasings.
- Consumer Skepticism (CS) returned α = 0.83 — confirming that the adapted Obermiller and Spangenberg items transfer well to the influencer context.
- Parasocial Relationship (PSR) returned α = 0.82 — indicating that the parasocial bond items form a coherent scale.
- Purchase Intention (PI) returned α = 0.73 — acceptable, though the interval is wide because the scale carries only three items.
- AI Content Awareness (ACA) returned α = 0.64 — below the threshold; this scale was developed for the present study, as no established measure of consumer awareness of generative AI exists.
- Content Transparency (CT) returned α = 0.64 — below the threshold; these items were developed from the disclosure literature rather than taken from a single validated scale.

The two sub-threshold results are informative rather than disqualifying. Both belong to the constructs for which no fully established prior scale existed, which is precisely the risk a pilot study is run to detect. Their confidence intervals are also wide — [0.43, 0.79] for AI Content Awareness and [0.42, 0.79] for Content Transparency — reflecting the modest pilot sample, so the point estimates should be read as an indication of where to look rather than as a final verdict on the scales.

4.2.4 Item-Total Statistics and Item Revision

To locate the source of the two sub-threshold alphas, corrected item-total correlations and alpha-if-item-deleted were computed for all 26 items. Three items fall below the conventional item-total correlation floor of .40: ACA1, ACA4 and CT3. No other item in the instrument falls below it.

Item	Corrected item-total r	α if item deleted	Decision
PA1	0.64	0.84	Retained
PA2	0.65	0.84	Retained
PA3	0.69	0.82	Retained
PA4	0.84	0.76	Retained
ACA1	0.30	0.65	Reworded
ACA2	0.52	0.51	Retained
ACA3	0.58	0.47	Retained
ACA4	0.33	0.66	Reworded
CT1	0.41	0.59	Retained
CT2	0.42	0.58	Retained
CT3	0.37	0.61	Reworded
CT4	0.50	0.52	Retained
PSR1	0.59	0.79	Retained

PSR2	0.77	0.71	Retained
PSR3	0.56	0.80	Retained
PSR4	0.64	0.77	Retained
CS1	0.58	0.83	Retained
CS2	0.70	0.77	Retained
CS3	0.72	0.77	Retained
CS4	0.67	0.79	Retained
BC1	0.78	0.79	Retained
BC2	0.77	0.80	Retained
BC3	0.71	0.86	Retained
PI1	0.53	0.67	Retained
PI2	0.58	0.60	Retained
PI3	0.54	0.65	Retained

Table 4.4 Item-Total Statistics (n = 41)

The alpha-if-deleted column points the same way for AI Content Awareness: removing either ACA1 (α = 0.65) or ACA4 (α = 0.66) would have raised the scale above its observed value of 0.64, which shows that these two items were suppressing the scale rather than contributing to it. CT3 carries the weakest item-total correlation within Content Transparency, although removing it alone would not have lifted that scale past the threshold.

Inspection of the three flagged items revealed a common defect. In each case the item asked the respondent to report a personal capability — whether they could detect AI involvement, or whether they could identify sponsorship — rather than a perception of the influencer's behaviour, which is what the constructs are defined to measure. ACA1 and ACA4 therefore captured self-assessed AI-detection skill instead of awareness that AI is being used, and CT3 captured self-assessed detection skill instead of disclosure by the influencer. Because the aim of the pilot was to improve the instrument rather than to shorten it, all three items were reworded to refer to the influencer's observable conduct rather than deleted. No item was added and none was removed, so the instrument retained 26 measurement items.

Item	Wording used in the pilot study	Wording used in the main study
ACA1	I can often tell when an influencer's content has been created using AI tools.	A lot of the influencer content I see appears to be created or edited using AI.
ACA4	When content looks too polished or perfect, I assume AI was involved.	I am aware that the influencers I follow likely use AI to help produce their content.
CT3	It's easy for me to tell when content from the influencers I follow is sponsored or AI-assisted.	The influencers I follow make it obvious when content is sponsored or AI-assisted.

Table 4.5 Item Revisions Following the Pilot Study

Because three items were reworded between the two phases, the pilot and main datasets are not measurement-equivalent and were not pooled. The pilot serves solely as instrument-development evidence, and all hypothesis testing is conducted on the main-study sample.

4.3 Main Study Data Collection

The revised instrument was distributed for the main study through social media, email and messaging applications, using convenience sampling with snowball referral. Collection ran from late June 2026 to late August 2026. The form received 389 submissions in total.

4.4 Composition of the Collected Sample

The total composition is 389 responses in main study which is retained for analysis. The sample is concentrated among younger social media users, which is consistent with the convenience and snowball sampling strategy and with the demographic profile of active influencer audiences in India. This concentration will be acknowledged as a limitation when the results are reported.

4.5 Data Preparation

The retained responses have been recoded from the Google Forms text labels into numeric form on the one-to-five scale, checked for missing values and exported in the format required for analysis in both Python and SmartPLS 4.0. The screening protocol is implemented as a reproducible script so that the analytical sample can be regenerated from the raw export.

4.6 Status of Analysis

Statistical analysis of the main study data is pending. No reliability, correlation, regression, mediation or structural equation modelling results are reported in this submission. The analyses listed in Section 3.5 will be carried out on the prepared dataset and reported in the final submission, following the schedule set out in Chapter 5.

4.7 Summary of Work Completed

- A review of the literature has now been finished, the review including more than 10 references published between 2024 and 2026.
- A conceptual model has been developed by combining four existing theories (the Persuasion Knowledge Model, Source Credibility Theory, Parasocial Interaction Theory and the Stimulus-Organism-Response framework), each of the constructs being linked to its theoretical origin in Table 2.1.
- A 26-item Likert questionnaire was created using proven scales.
- A study has been carried out and produced 55 responses, after which three of the items have been reworded.
- The main data collection is complete, having received 389 submissions.
- The screening protocol was applied and the dataset was prepared for analysis.

CHAPTER 5

FUTURE SCOPE OF WORK

The remaining work consists of the statistical analysis of the Main Study dataset and the writing of the final report. The analysis will proceed in four stages.

The first stage covers descriptive statistics, tests of normality and assessment of internal consistency reliability, together with Harman's single-factor test for common method bias. The second stage covers correlation and multiple regression analysis, with collinearity and residual diagnostics, to provide a preliminary examination of the hypothesised relationships. The third stage covers bootstrapped mediation analysis using 5,000 resamples with bias-corrected confidence intervals, testing the intervening role of Consumer Skepticism and of Brand Credibility. The fourth stage covers partial least squares structural equation modelling in SmartPLS 4.0, comprising measurement model assessment, structural model assessment and bootstrapping with 5,000 subsamples.

The final report will include the results along with an analysis of the findings, a examination of their theoretical and managerial implications, a statement of the study's limitations and suggestions for future research. The limitations that were identified in advance cover the sample size, since this allows reliable detection of standardised path coefficients of 0.21 or higher only; the fact that the sample consists mainly of younger people; the cross-sectional design, which enables the drawing of conclusions about association but not about causal direction; and the fact that the AI Content Awareness scale was developed for the present study and has not been validated in other samples.

The remaining schedule is as follows: statistical analysis in September 2026, interpretation and report writing in September and October 2026, and the final presentation in October 2026.

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ANNEXURE I

Survey Questionnaire as Administered

All construct items use a five-point scale: 1 = Strongly Disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neutral, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly Agree.

Section A: Consent and Screening

1. I agree to participate in this survey. [Yes / No]
2. Do you follow any social media influencer? [Yes / No]
3. Have you seen influencer-promoted content in the past 6 months? [Yes / No / Not sure]

Section B: Demographics

4. Age: [Below 18 / 18–24 / 25–34 / 35–44 / 45+]
5. Gender: [Male / Female / Other / Prefer not to say]
6. How often do you use social media? [Multiple times daily / Daily / Several times a week / Weekly / Rarely]
7. Which platforms do you use most? [Instagram / YouTube / Twitter-X / LinkedIn / Snapchat / Facebook / Other] (multiple selection permitted)

Section C: Perceived Authenticity (PA)

PA1. The influencers I follow create content that feels genuine and personal.

PA2. I believe the influencers I follow share their real opinions about products.

PA3. The content from my favourite influencers feels natural, not scripted.

PA4. I trust that the influencers I follow are being true to themselves in their posts.

Section D: AI Content Awareness (ACA)

ACA1. A lot of the influencer content I see appears to be created or edited using AI.

ACA2. I frequently suspect that influencer posts are written or edited by AI.

ACA3. I often think the content I see was made with AI tools like ChatGPT or Midjourney.

ACA4. I am aware that the influencers I follow likely use AI to help produce their content.

Section E: Content Transparency (CT)

CT1. The influencers I follow clearly state when a post is sponsored or paid.

CT2. When the influencers I follow use AI tools, they openly disclose it.

CT3. The influencers I follow make it obvious when content is sponsored or AI-assisted.

CT4. The influencers I follow are upfront about how their content is made.

Section F: Parasocial Relationship (PSR)

PSR1. I feel like I know the influencers I follow personally.

PSR2. When I watch or read content from my favourite influencer, I feel like I am spending time with a friend.

PSR3. I look forward to seeing new content from the influencers I follow.

PSR4. I feel emotionally connected to the influencers I regularly follow.

Section G: Consumer Skepticism (CS)

CS1. I am skeptical about the sincerity of influencer product recommendations.

CS2. I question whether influencers truly use the products they promote.

CS3. I believe most influencer content is designed primarily to sell, not to inform.

CS4. Influencer reviews often feel more like ads than honest opinions.

Section H: Brand Credibility (BC)

BC1. Brands promoted through influencer marketing seem trustworthy to me.

BC2. I see brands recommended by influencers as credible.

BC3. Influencer endorsements make me perceive the brand as more reliable and competent.

Section I: Purchase Intention (PI)

PI1. I am likely to buy a product after seeing an influencer recommend it.

PI2. I would consider buying a product sooner because an influencer I follow recommended it.

PI3. I would choose an influencer-recommended product over alternatives.

Section J: Quality Check

QC1. I carefully read the questions in this survey.

Section K: Open-Ended (Optional)

Please describe a memorable experience where you felt an influencer's content was either genuinely authentic or suspiciously AI-generated. What made you feel that way?

Note. Items ACA1, ACA4 and CT3 were reworded following the pilot study. Both the pilot and the revised wordings are recorded in Table 4.1.